For all their bravado, the Portuguese should have recognized their situation when, in the summer of 1954, a small group of local activists simply took over the government in Dadra and in Nagar-Haveli. It was not immediately absorbed into India and for a while it remained an independent country in the eyes of international law! The Portuguese responded by bolstering their defences in the remaining territories with African troops from Portuguese East Africa (now Mozambique). Protests and strikes were severely put down and thousands were arrested. Prime Minister Nehru had hoped that the matter would be eventually resolved through negotiation but, by late 1961, patience had run out.

Operation Vijay began with the Indian Air Force bombing Dabolim airport at dawn on 18 December 1961. This is the same airport that tourists use today when they fly to Goa. Within hours, Indian ground troops were pouring into Goa from the north, south and east. The Indian Navy pressed in from the west. Similar operations were carried out simultaneously against the other enclaves of Daman and Diu. Lisbon had instructed the defenders to fight to the end, but they simply had no chance against such overwhelming force. The only show of defiance came from *NRP Alfonso de Albuquerque*, the sole Portuguese warship in Goa. Built in the 1930s, it was a medium-sized frigate that was outmoded and hopelessly outgunned by the large, modern fleet it faced on the morning of 18 December. By noon, it was engaged by two Indian frigates at the entrance of Marmagao port. The two sides exchanged fire but, within half an hour, *Alfonso de Albuquerque* was no longer a functioning ship. The crew then ran it aground near Dona Paula beach and used it as a fixed battery. They defiantly kept firing the guns for another hour and a half till they stopped due to mounting casualties and a lack of ammunition. The Portuguese had come to India with cannons firing from their ships, and they left in the same way. Yet another of the circularities of Indian history.

Barely thirty-six hours after the invasion began, the Portuguese Governor General Vassalo e Silva saw the futility of his position and signed the document of unconditional surrender. It was Christmas season, but Lisbon was in mourning. ‘Cinemas and theatres shut down as thousands marched